

Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself

THE STORY

1. Who or what do I think is the cause of my suffering?
2. What feelings am I experiencing? (*Highlight all the words below that describe your feelings and make a note of any others not listed here*)

Longing	Anxious	Defeated	Aggressive	Grief/loss
Exposed	Violated	Embarrassed	Chaotic	Shame
Rigid/numb	Disrespected	Deprived	Hurt/pain	Sad
Threatened	Disillusioned	Indignant	Abused	Vindictive
Enraged/angry	Meaningless	Self-loathing	Abandoned	Intolerant
Resentful	Obsessing	Attacked	Cheated	Rejected
Frustrated	Powerless/trapped	Overwhelmed	Restless	Compulsive
Failure	Helpless	Panic	Tired	Put-upon
Not good enough	Hopeless	Guilt/punishable	Worthless	Polluted

3. What other symptoms am I experiencing (e.g., shaking or wringing hands, bingeing, sleeplessness, loss of appetite, twitches, digestive distress, headaches, unsafe driving or self-destructive choices, fatigue, awkwardness, heart issues, faintness, inner conversations, tight throat and chest, numbness/no feeling)?

4. Have I experienced this type of suffering before? (***Y** for yes and **N** for no*) **Y / N**

5. Anniversary trauma: Do I feel this way at the same time every month or every year? **Y / N**

Is there an experience that chronically triggers these feelings? **Y / N**

If yes, in what way and for how long?

PRIDE

1. How *should* this situation be? Write down a plain statement of fact.
2. What judgment am I making about this situation? Is it good or bad? Why?

3. What stories am I using to explain my fear and justify my suffering? (*Highlight those that apply and make notes if you wish*)

- Fortune-telling: predicting the future and basing feelings on that prediction
- Disaster fantasies: creating nightmare scenarios above and beyond current facts
- Guilt and punishment: expecting punishment for doing, neglecting, or allowing something
- Mind-reading: imputing thoughts and motives to others
- Personalizing: interpreting circumstances and the actions of others as a personal attack
- Punching: choosing loaded words to reinforce my feelings or create more drama
- Extreme thinking: using absolute terms like always, every, never, best, etc.
- Over-generalizing: globalizing a few incidents into general experience
- Magic: expecting results from no real effort and denying the reality of cause and effect
- Discounting: ignoring the positive aspects of a situation
- Unfairness: judging a situation or event to be unfair
- Dismissing: "If it weren't for . . . everything would be fine."
- Logical conclusions: focusing on one logical conclusion that excludes possibilities
- Dead end thinking: "I had to do it [think it, feel it, choose it] because . . ."
- Deja vu: "It's all going to happen all over again."

You might like to write down your own virtue story. Here are some examples: *I would make a mess. I just have high standards. I want to protect you. God wouldn't like it. I'm loyal to my friends/beliefs. I'm taking care of myself/others. I'm the only one who can handle it. It feels right—I just know. I'm unselfish. I'm special/handicapped. I need to feel supported and understood. My intentions are good.*

THE MIRROR

1. Will you take responsibility for your participation in, and the perpetuation of, your suffering? **Y / N**
2. Will you accept the possibility that you may be creating your own suffering? **Y / N**
3. Does this suffering reveal that there is an area of your life that needs to change? **Y / N**
4. Are you willing to make necessary changes? **Y / N**
5. Does this suffering reveal hurt pride and the need to be right? **Y / N**
6. Are you more willing to be well than to be right? **Y / N**

WISDOM

1. Do you want to learn wisdom from above? **Y / N**
2. Look at these two lists based on James 3:13–18. What kind of wisdom have you chosen in this time of suffering? *(Highlight the words or phrases that apply to you)*

Wisdom from above

Cleverness in practical matters
Skill
Excellent behavior
Using tools gently
Holiness
Mercy and compassion
Producing good outcomes

Wisdom from below

Inner conflicts
Competing for resources
Compelling selfish ambition
Taking cheap, habitual shortcuts to relieve tension
Lost connection with heaven
Egocentricity
Producing disorder

GUIDING YOURSELF INTO JOY

1. Are you willing to allow the possibility that your current suffering is for your training? **Y / N**
2. Do you share God's vision for you to be complete and lacking in nothing, according to His design? **Y / N**
3. Which areas of your life reveal a need for more training?

ACTION

Use a tap, TAT, Healing Color, UFO Hold, or meditation to calm the fear and to integrate the work you have done. Then, consider the following questions.

1. Am I asking, seeking, and knocking to find help? **Y / N**

2. What might be the next step to help relieve my suffering?

3. What long-term practice will help prevent or modify this suffering in the future?

PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,
I can see this suffering as a path toward growing into the person You created me to be. I want to take responsibility for my part in my suffering. I am willing to give up my ideas of how life should be on my terms and respond to life as it is. Support me as I use this time of suffering to explore my illusions, my weaknesses, and the quality of my faith. Bring me to a healing space. I will use the tools and support that You have given me. I will rejoice in learning the truth about these areas of my life that still need training. I trust You to build the character I need to fulfill my mission for the glory and honor of my Lord Jesus. Amen.